

GENERAL STUDIES - 4
ASCEND TEST 8

Time Allowed: **Three Hours**

Maximum Marks: **250**

Question Paper Specific Instructions:

1. There are **12** questions printed in **ENGLISH**.
 2. All questions are compulsory.
 3. The number of marks carried by a question/part is indicated against it.
 4. Word limit in questions, if specified, should be adhered to.
 5. Any page or portion of the page left blank in the Question-Cum Answer Booklet must be clearly Struck off.
 6. Do furnish the appropriate details in the answer sheet (viz. Name, Email, Roll No, Mobile).
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Q1. (a) Moral values are not universal principles of thought, but practices developed by groups of human beings. Examine (10 marks, 150 words)

(b) How important is it for laws to be in harmony with the moral values of a society? Illustrate your answer with examples. (10 marks, 150 words)

Q2. (a) Differentiate between the following: (10 Marks, 150 Words)

- (i) Accountability and responsibility
- (ii) Normative ethics and Descriptive ethics

(b) Examine how gender diversity in leadership roles can enhance ethical governance in India. Provide examples to support your answer. (10 marks, 150 words)

Q3. (a) In an age dominated by technology, to what extent digital advancements transformed decision-making into a more ethical process in administration. (10 marks, 150 words)

(b) In the age of social media, is the traditional anonymity of civil servants still a desirable practice? Examine (10 marks, 150 words)

Q4. (a) How does Emotional Intelligence (EI) enhance the ethical standards of civil servants and influence their interactions with the public? (10 marks, 150 words)

(b) What is social intelligence, and how does it complement emotional intelligence in public administration? Explain. (10 marks, 150 words)

Q5. (a) Discuss the need of a social accountability law in India in light of the perceived weakening of civil servants' accountability mechanisms. (10 marks, 150 words)

(b) Probity in governance is essential for an efficient and effective governance. Discuss. Also, suggest ways to enhance probity in governance. (10 marks, 150 words)

Q6. What do the following quotations mean to you in the present context and context of public service.

(a) "Human behavior stems from three primary sources: desire, emotions, and knowledge." Discuss. (10 marks, 150 words)

(b) "Strive not to be a success, but rather to be of value." (10 marks, 150 words)

(c) "Discretionary power is essential for governance but also prone to misuse." (10 marks, 150 words)

Section B

Q7. You are the Chairman of the Complaints committee of National Sports Authority, and recently, you have appointed a new National cycling coach. He is a very acclaimed figure in the field and comes with a lot of recommendations. Since his appointment, the performance of the team has also considerably improved. This time, there are high hopes with the cycling team that they would secure top spot in the upcoming Asian championship.

During a foreign exposure trip, the Coach behaved inappropriately with one of the best performing cyclists Ms. X, she felt disturbed by the act and could not concentrate on her training but fearing shame and ostracization she ignored his undue gestures and tried to focus on the championship. One evening he forcefully entered inside the room of Ms. X and pulled her towards himself.

Ms. X approaches you telephonically, she is in shock and narrates her ordeal to you. You are an empathetic officer and take these matters seriously but taking any action at this stage is very likely to disrupt the training process of Cyclists and consequently the aspirations of team to secure a medal at the upcoming Asian Championship. She, however, is very inconsolable and threatens to commit suicide naming and shaming the National Sports Authority, the coach, and you if her grievances are not addressed. The problem has now become very complex. You find yourself in a serious ethical conundrum, with your personal and professional life now at stake as well.

(a) Identify the ethical issues involved in the case.

(b) What are the options available to you? Evaluating each option, write the option you would adopt, giving reasons. (20 marks, 250 words)

Q8. You are a senior civil servant in a state where corruption and lack of transparency have been persistent challenges in government operations. A new government has come into power with a strong mandate and a pledge to eradicate corruption and improve governance. As part of this commitment, the government has introduced a series of stringent measures aimed at increasing transparency and accountability in public procurement processes.

You are tasked with overseeing the implementation of these measures and ensuring that from now onwards, all the government contracts are awarded based on fair and competitive bidding. However, you soon realize that there is resistance from influential political and business circles who are accustomed to benefiting from under-the-table deals and preferential treatment in procurement. Some of these individuals have close ties to high-ranking officials within the government.

In this pressure, you receive a proposal from a well-connected business conglomerate for a major infrastructure project that promises substantial economic growth for the region. However, upon preliminary review, you uncover evidence suggesting that the bidding process through which they got the contract may have been tweaked in their favour, there are also indications of potential collusion among bidders and officials of previous dispensation.

Alerted about your actions, the conglomerate sends their representative to convince you by saying that there has been no violation of law in the said case, and they have caused no harm to the exchequer. He eventually promises you an industrial plot in one of the already completed projects of the firm in a neighbouring state to 'settle' the case.

Furthermore, you are due to retire in a few months. Your pensions and post-retirement benefits may not be enough to cover the expenses of treatment of your wife who has recently been diagnosed with cancer and is undergoing treatment at a leading hospital. At this juncture, the above proposal seems like a win-win situation.

At the same time, you are well aware that your actions will set a precedent for future procurement decisions and contribute to the overall trajectory of governance reforms in the state. You are now faced with a question. On one hand, approving the project could unquestionably stimulate economic development and create jobs, which aligns with the government's goals. On the other hand, endorsing a process that might undermine the renewed commitment to transparency and integrity and would erode public trust, perpetuating corrupt practices.

- (a) What are the options available to you in the above situation?
- (b) Critically examine the options identified by you.
- (c) What are the ethical dilemmas faced by you in the exercise of your options.

- (d) Can you suggest a mechanism to address the malice of corruption at higher levels?
(20 marks, 250 words)

Q9. In a resource rich tribal state, a district has been facing the issue of efficient utilization of non-timber forest produce like tamarind, moringa, mahua etc. The stocks have been piling up in forest department's warehouses and are being eaten by rodents. This has been causing considerable loss to revenue as the rodents are also destroying priceless red sanders stored nearby.

A newly appointed District Forest Officer (DFO) came up with an innovative solution to this problem. She incentivized local women to form self-help groups (SHG) and formed a contract with them for utilization of the minor forest produce. The formula is simple yet effective. The self-help groups participate in auctions conducted by the forest department and procure the raw material. They then make products like facewash, shampoo, and soap from it. The forest department buys back majority of these products and sells them through the TRIFED operated shops under the Tribes India scheme of the government, improving its market value.

This has considerably reduced the stockpile of minor forest products in the warehouses and has generated additional revenue for the department as well as the women of these self-help groups. While this has generated considerable public interest and appreciation for the officer, it has also attracted some ill-intentioned people.

The local MLA has approached the DFO through her representative asking to be given a cut in the revenue generated. A veiled threat has also been made, if by month's end the asked funds are not sent, the officer would be transferred to a Naxal affected division. At her wit's end due to all such pressures the officer tries to bring the issue to the notice of her superior officer. She is refused help from all quarters and is advised to give the money asked for by the MLA as the MLA has a close standing with the Chief Minister himself.

- (a) What options does the DFO have in dealing with the situation at hand?
(b) If any innovative actions by a civil servant are rewarded by punishments, would they remain committed and dedicated to service?
(c) How can a system of appreciation be included in the administrative structure which is ruled by punishments and red tapes?
(20 marks, 250 words)

Q10. You are the Secretary, School, and mass education department of a state with a tribal dominated population. In the recently concluded high school examination, over 76% students failed to turn up appear in the examinations, the absenteeism was more marked in the tribal heartland, attributed to dipping interest in online classes and migration in search of work.

After conducting a preliminary enquiry, you found that the COVID-19 pandemic induced prolonged closure of schools, shortage of teachers, poor quality of education, lack of high schools and inadequate hostel facilities have resulted in some students taking up jobs and others opting for early marriage. These events had a demonstrating effect on other children as well leading to mass dropouts.

The problem was even more glaring for girl students. Many girls studying in government hostels for Scheduled Tribe (ST) and Scheduled Caste (SC) students had to abruptly return to their villages. With the lack of mobile phones, access to online classes was non-existent. Also, the teachers did not perform the task of counselling as per expectations. Female students became vulnerable to child marriage and teenage motherhood, performing household chores with babies in a sling.

The NGOs working in this field have also given you certain input. At many places, villages have been producing semi literates for generations as they only have a primary school. At others, schools are 6-7 km away in forest areas which are not safe for a girl child to walk. Due to lack of monitoring, teachers in such village schools do not come to school on time. The government's effort to start a mobile school program to bridge the learning gaps has not met with expected results due to gap in outreach and funds. With the end of lockdown, the situation across the state is returning to normalcy, but for you, it presents a triple challenge of improving the quality of offline education, tracking the dropout children, and bringing them back to the class and finally bridging the learning gaps created in the past two years.

- (a) As a senior officer entrusted with the responsibility, how are you going to address the above issues?
 - (b) In the long term, how can you improve the quality-of-service delivery in the education department with special emphasis on tribal and other vulnerable sections?
- (20 marks, 250 words)

Q11. You are the chief executive of IndElectron, an electronics company which makes computer hardware and equipment for heavy machinery and automobiles. In your production plants, complex hydrocarbon solvents are used to clean the chips and other parts that go into the computer components. Some of the solvents used are carcinogens and must be handled with extreme care. Until recently, all your production plants were in India, However, owing to new environmental laws and rising cost of production, profits have declined.

A number of factors have increased production costs. First, the union representing the workers in your plant waged a successful strike resulting in increased salary and benefits. A second factor has been stringent safety regulations. These safety procedures, which apply inside the plant, have been expensive in both time and

money. Finally, environmental regulations have made IndElectron's operations more costly as the company is required to put its waste through an expensive process before depositing it at a special disposal facility.

Shareholders have been complaining to you about the declining fortunes of the company. Many of IndElectron's competitors have moved their operations to neighbouring countries, where their operating costs are less than in India and you have begun to consider whether to relocate the plants to offshore sites. IndElectron is a major employer in each of the cities where it is located, and you know that a plant closure will cause economic dislocation in these communities.

You know that the employees who will be laid off because of plant closures will have difficulty finding equivalent positions and that increased unemployment, with its attendant social costs, will result. However, you are aware of many other corporations, including your competitors, that have shut down their Indian operations, and it is something that you are willing to consider.

You have hired a consultant to investigate the sites for possible plant relocation. She has years of experience working with companies that have moved their operations to less-developed countries to reduce their operating costs and bypass norms. After fully investigating the possibilities and options, she has advised you to move your operations to a neighboring country with "less stringent" labor and environmental norms.

In such conditions, valid arguments can be advanced for options of moving your business as well as staying put.

- (a) Indicate various options that you think are available in this situation.
- (b) How would you evaluate these options? Also suggest the best way out.

(20 marks, 250 words)

Q12. Anuradha has been appointed the District Magistrate (DM) of a hilly district famous for much revered pilgrimage site. Nestled amidst the Himalayas, the district is prone to various natural disasters that threaten its ecological stability as well as the livelihood of its residents. The local populace, primarily engaged in the tourism sector, caters to the large influx of tourists from across India and abroad.

Shortly after Anuradha took charge the district faced a devastating earthquake. The aftermath is dire. There has been a staggering loss of lives and widespread destruction of critical infrastructure like roads and bridges. The calamity leaves both residents and tourists stranded at various destinations; their paths blocked by debris. Amidst such chaos, a convoy of foreign delegates from a country with whom India has recently

been having a few diplomatic setbacks, had been on their way to pay respects at the holy site. They have now been caught in one of the destroyed roads.

Anuradha faces an ethical challenge as she deals with allocating limited resources to the rescue of these delegates and that of the larger public. This decision has been a cause for a moral dilemma between saving the lives of the few and that of many. While the rescue effort for the delegates carries diplomatic implications, the citizens who are equally needful of the help have to face prolonged hardship and emotional distress due to delay in assistance.

This delay in addressing the urgent needs of the affected individuals triggers a breakdown in law and order. The dejection erupts as the people perceive the authorities' response as partial and favoring the elite. Anuradha confronts another challenge *viz.* prioritizing the immediate need of rescue and maintaining public order while ensuring that the country's diplomatic interests are protected.

Subsequently, Anuradha is faced with many considerations, which range from prioritizing international diplomacy to rescue of citizenry to managing law and order during a grave disaster.

- (a) Identify the ethical dilemmas faced by Anuradha.
- (b) How can Anuradha prioritize between the conflicting needs in the instant case?
What are the factors that would influence her decisions? (20 marks, 250 words)